



Saint Columban College
College of Computing Studies
Pagadian City



Secrets

Secrets 



Medium Web Exploitation picoCTF 2022

AUTHOR: GEOFFREY NJOGU

Description

We have several pages hidden. Can you find the one with the flag?
Additional details will be available after launching your challenge instance.

This challenge launches an instance on demand.

Its current status is: **NOT_RUNNING**

Launch Instance

Hints

1

folders folders folders

29,055 users solved



76% Liked



 picoCTF{FLAG}

Submit Flag

Author: The Analyst: Hyposelenia

Challenge: Secrets

Category: Web Exploitation

Date: 02/28/26



I. Objective

The objective of this challenge is to discover a hidden flag by exploring **hidden directories** on a website that are not directly visible through normal browsing. This challenge teaches how websites can contain **secret paths** that are accessible only if the correct URL is manually entered.

II. Background

Websites are made up of folders and files, similar to how a computer stores documents in directories. Not all folders are meant to be seen by regular users. Some directories are hidden simply because there are **no links pointing to them**, not because they are protected by passwords.

In cybersecurity, attackers often look for **unlinked or hidden directories** by guessing common folder names or following hints. This challenge demonstrates how sensitive information can be exposed if developers rely only on “hiding” folders instead of properly securing them.

III. Tool Used

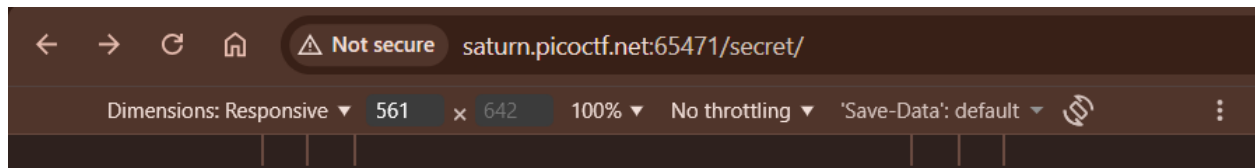
- **Web Browser** - Used to access and interact with the challenge website
- **Browser Developer Tools (Inspect)** - Used to view the HTML source code of the webpage to locate hidden information such as comments or embedded flags.

IV. Methodology

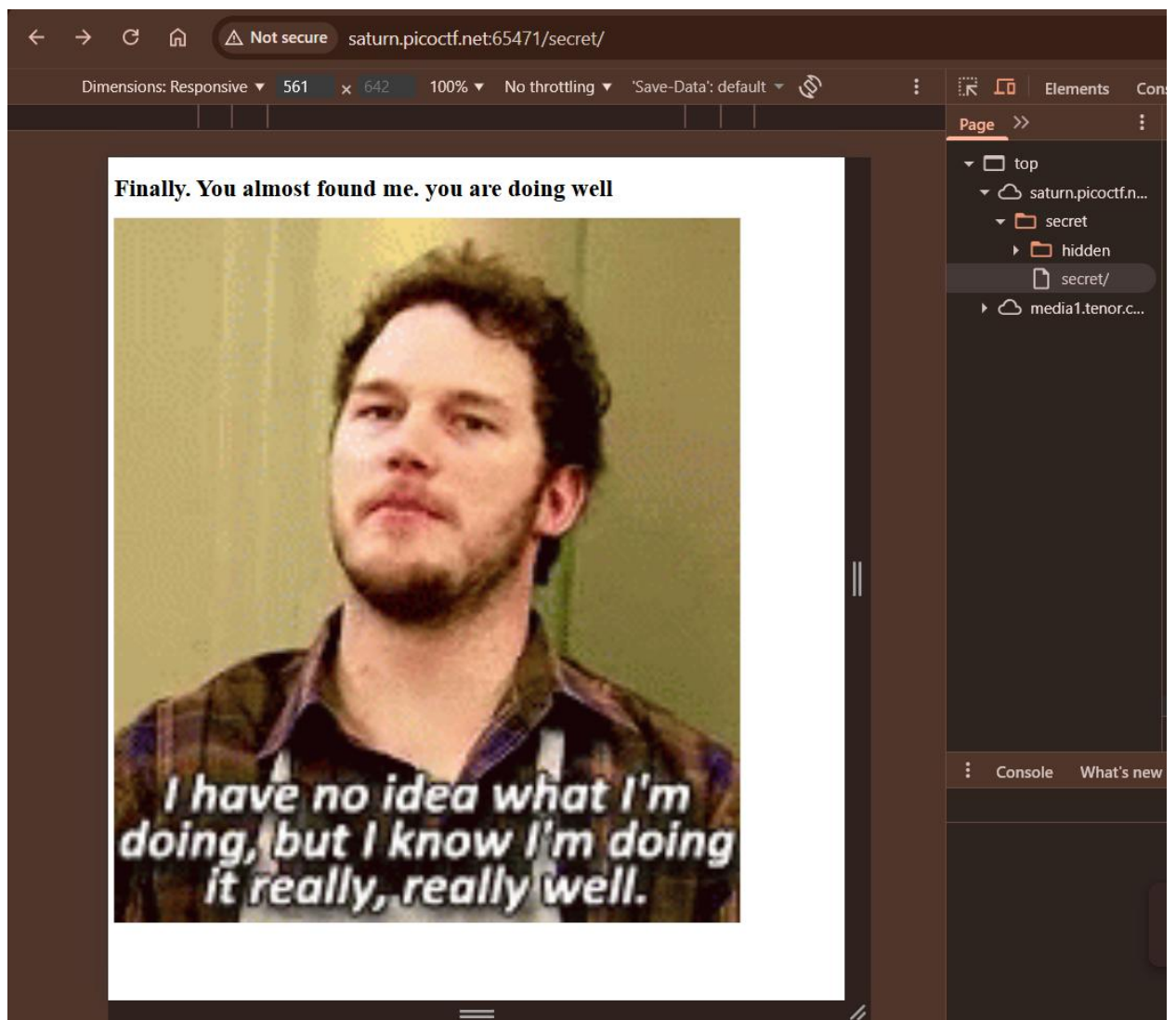
1. Launched the challenge instance.



- ## Launch Instance

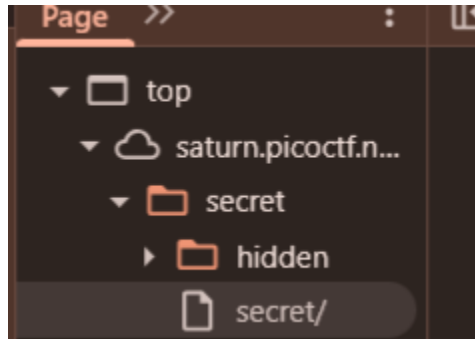


5. Upon accessing `/secret/`, a directory structure appeared, confirming that the folder existed even though it was not linked anywhere on the site.

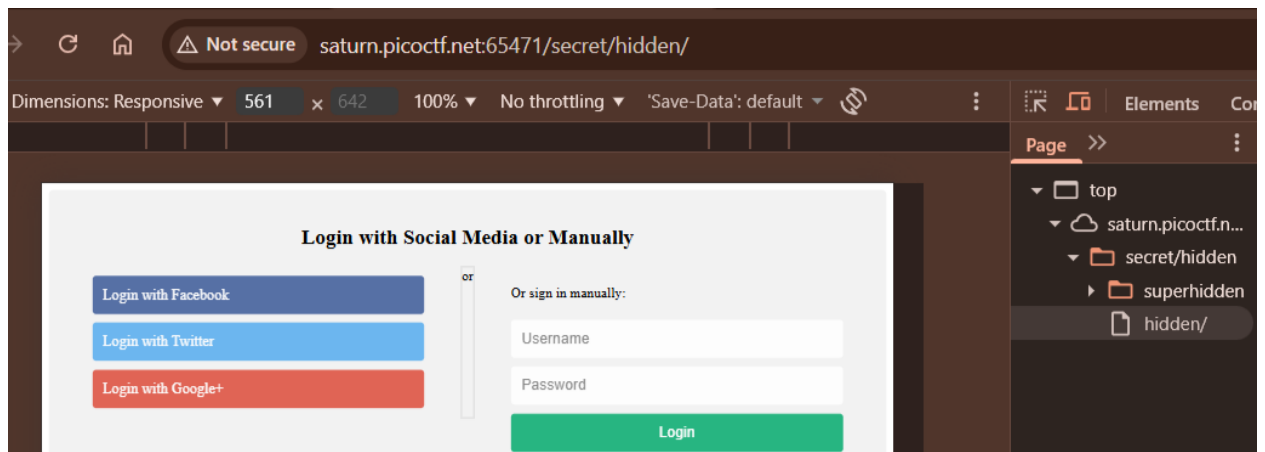




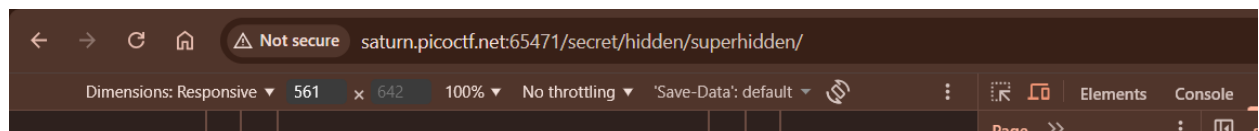
6. Noticed a folder named `hidden` and accessed it by appending `/hidden/` to the URL.



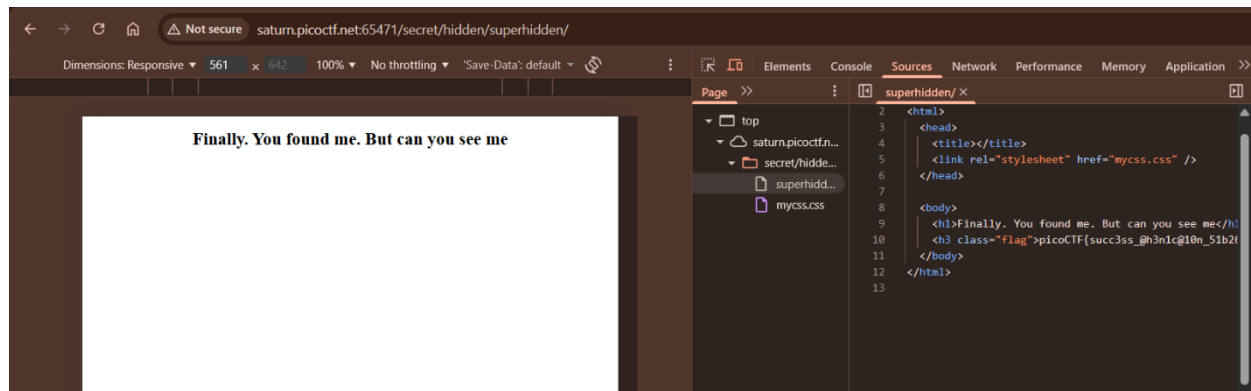
7. Inside the `hidden` directory, another folder named `superhidden` was discovered.



8. Accessed `/secret/hidden/superhidden/`.

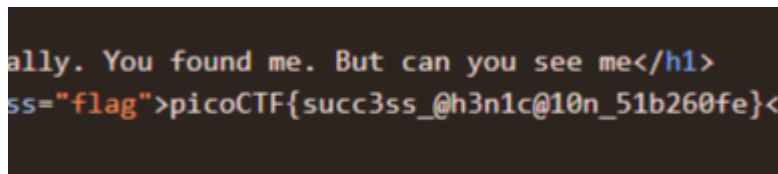


9. Inspected the HTML source code of this page and discovered the flag hidden within the page structure.



V. Result

`picoCTF{succ3ss_@h3n1c@10n_51b260fe}`



VI. Explanation

Imagine a **school building**:

- Some rooms have doors and signs (visible pages).
- Some rooms have doors but **no signs pointing to them** (hidden directories).
- Just because you don't see a sign doesn't mean the room doesn't exist.

Why /secret didn't work but /secret/ did

- /secret is like saying the *name* of a room.
- /secret/ is like **opening the door** to that room.
- Web servers treat folders differently when the trailing slash (/) is missing.



Why hidden folders still exist

Folders like hidden and superhidden existed because:

- They were created on the server
- But **not linked** anywhere on the website
- Anyone who guesses the correct path can still access them

This is called **security by obscurity**, which means:

“I’ll hide it and hope nobody finds it.”

That is **not real security**!

VII. Conclusion

This challenge teaches that **hidden does not mean secure**. Any directory that exists on a server can be accessed if someone guesses or discovers its path. Proper security requires authentication and access control, not just hiding folders.

From a cybersecurity perspective, this challenge emphasizes the importance of:

- Securing sensitive directories
- Avoiding reliance on obscurity
- Regularly auditing web server file structures

Understanding how attackers explore hidden paths is essential for both defending and building secure web applications.

— The Analyst: Hyposelenia